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Week 2 Lit Example Worksheet

MACBETH: SHIFTING WORDS, SHIFTING REASONS

Purpose: Apply Week 2's Whately method to Macbeth. Define important terms, separate different senses of the same word, and test whether the reasoning still works.

Directions: Use the Lit Example Reader. Quote only briefly. Write in complete, precise sentences. Do not merely say that Shakespeare is using a theme or symbol; explain how a word's meaning affects an inference.

Part 1: Fair and Foul

Question 1.1

In the first passage, identify two possible meanings of *fair* and two possible meanings of *foul*. Then explain why confusing moral meaning with outward appearance or favorable outcome could mislead Macbeth.

Part 1 Q1

Question 1.2

Macbeth says, "So foul and fair a day I have not seen." Does this line by itself prove a contradiction, or can the words be using different senses? Explain the logical difference.

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Part 1 Q2

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Part 2: What Counts as a Man?

Question 2.1

Reconstruct Macbeth's use of *man*: what does he mean when he says, "I dare do all that may become a man; / Who dares do more is none"? State the term, Macbeth's sense of it, and the limit he is drawing.

Part 2 Q1

Question 2.2

Reconstruct Lady Macbeth's use of *man*: what does she imply when she says Macbeth was a man when he dared the murder and would be "so much more the man" if he did it? State her sense of the term and explain whether her argument depends on a shift in meaning.

Part 2 Q2

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Part 3: Done and Settled

Question 3.1

Macbeth says, “If it were done when ’tis done.” Identify at least two senses of *done* in this passage. Then explain why physically completing an action does not prove that its consequences or moral judgment are finished.

Part 3 Q1

Part 4: Testing an Equivocation

Question 4.1

Choose either *fair/foul*, *man*, or *done*. Build a short argument that would become unreliable if that word changed meaning halfway through. Then rewrite the argument with the term clarified so the shift is visible.

Part 4 Q1